Buncombe County Schools
K-5 Dual Language Spanish Immersion Program
Frequently Asked Questions for Parents

Get the facts on the BCS K-5 Dual Language Spanish Immersion (DL/I) program.

As a parent, you play an important role in your child's education. If you are considering a language immersion program, you need to know how to help your child develop the best possible language and literacy skills, while also supporting their achievement in the basics. We have developed this list of frequently asked questions for the DL/I program to help you make informed decisions.

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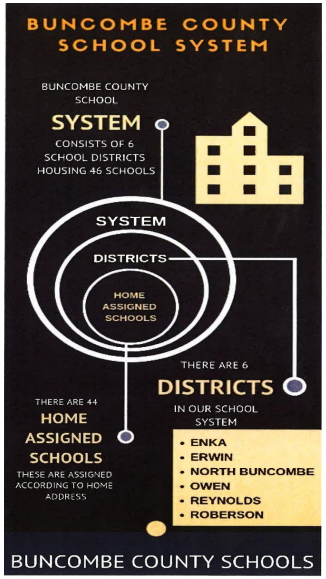
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Program Overview	
What is a dual language Spanish immersion program?	The focus of the Buncombe County Schools Kindergarten-5th Grade Dual Language / Immersion (BCS K-5 DL/I) program is to help students become proficient in both Spanish and English while mastering subject content across all disciplines. In the BCS K-5 DL/I program, Spanish is not taught as a subject; it is the medium in which core instruction is delivered. Research shows the most effective way for children to acquire a second language is to integrate instruction into the standard curriculum children are already learning.
What are the benefits of the BCS K-5 DL/I program?	In an increasingly diverse and connected world, the ability to speak two languages gives children a broader cultural understanding, a greater appreciation of cultural diversity, and a competitive edge as well as career opportunities. The mental, academic, and future benefits are sound - critical and logical thinking, problem solving, and decision making are strengthened. Research shows that students in DL/I programs outperform students in traditional language classes; they do as well as or better than non-immersion students on standardized tests. Research shows that DL/I programs benefit a variety of learners, including academically and intellectually gifted students, non-native English speakers, students with exceptionalities, and students from varying socioeconomic backgrounds.
What does the BCS K-5 DL/I program look like?	The two models used in the BCS K-5 DL/I program are described by the North Carolina Department of Instruction (NCDPI) as follows: ● Two-way immersion programs: These programs group native speakers of English with native speakers of Spanish. The mix is approximately 50 percent of each group and both become bilingual, biliterate and bicultural. Instruction is provided both in English and in Spanish. Percentages like 90/10 and 50/50 are used to refer to how much of the instruction at different grade levels is provided in Spanish versus how much is provided in English. ● One-way/Full immersion programs: These programs typically serve children coming from English-speaking homes in an environment where Spanish is used exclusively until 2nd grade. The students become bilingual, biliterate, and bicultural and are equally proficient in both languages, with near-native fluency in Spanish. It is important to note that schools may slide up and down the scale of immersion, meaning that students may move from 90/10 to 50/50 given specific school situations and student populations.
What languages can my child learn?	The BCS K-5 DL/I program is a Spanish immersion program. Your child will learn both Spanish and English.
Is the BCS K-5 DL/I program taught by native Spanish-speaking teachers?	Teachers in the BCS K-5 DL/I program may be native or non-native speakers fluent in Spanish and meet state certification requirements.

Eligibility	
Who is eligible to enroll in the BCS K-5 DL/I program?	Kindergarten - Grade 1: Enrollment begins in Kindergarten and may continue through the first nine (9) weeks of 1st grade, contingent upon seat availability, student readiness, and administrator approval. For students who enroll in the DL/I program after the start of Kindergarten, additional academic supports may be necessary. Grades 2-5: ● *Students entering with immersion experience:* DL/I transfer students entering grades K-5 will be admitted to the BCS K-5 DL/I program, pending available space. ● *Students entering without immersion experience:* Students who have not had continuous immersion experience are rarely admitted after the first nine (9) weeks of 1st grade due to the nature of the immersion experience and rising expectations per grade level. Unique circumstances may exist and will be examined on a case-by-case basis to ensure appropriate placement for student success.
Is the BCS K-5 DL/I program appropriate for my student?	It is important for all parents/guardians to visit a BCS K-5 DL/I program before making an enrollment decision. Immersion may not be the optimal learning environment for every student. Parents who feel their child may have significant communication delays in their first language should make an appointment with the school staff to weigh the pros and cons of enrolling their child in the BCS K-5 DL/I program.
Is the BCS K-5 DL/I program appropriate only for high-performing students?	No. Research shows that immersion education can be effective for a wide variety of learners, including academically and intellectually gifted students, non-native English speakers, students with exceptionalities, and students from varying socioeconomic backgrounds.
Enrollment Procedures	
Where is DL/I available in BCS? What type of program is offered at each school?	BCS offers the K-5 Dual Language Spanish Immersion in the following elementary and intermediate schools: ● Avery's Creek Elementary – Roberson District; Two-way immersion program ● Candler Elementary – Enka District; One-way/Full immersion program ● Glen Arden Elementary – Roberson District; One-way/Full immersion program ● Koontz Intermediate – Roberson District; Two-way immersion program (Grade 5 only) ● North Buncombe Elementary – North Buncombe District; One-way/Full immersion program ● Oakley Elementary – Reynolds District; Two-way immersion program ● W.D. Williams Elementary – Owen District; Two-way immersion program ● West Buncombe Elementary – Erwin District; Two-way immersion program

What are the procedures for Kindergarten application and enrollment?	Each BCS K-5 DL/I school will host an information session for parents during Kindergarten Orientation. Families of rising Kindergarten students are encouraged to contact the school or visit the school website for specific dates and times of Kindergarten Orientation. School tours and additional parent information sessions may be offered at each BCS K-5 DL/I school. The application period begins on the first student day in January and ends May 15. Pending enrollment interest, applications may continue to be accepted until classes reach capacity. 1. Parents wishing to enroll a student in the BCS K-5 DL/I program must first fill out a BCS Dual Language Spanish Immersion Application. The application can be found on the BCS website and the website of each BCS K-5 DL/I school. The school office can also provide you with a copy. It is a good idea to keep a copy of the application on file for your records. 2. Families residing outside of the Home Assigned School's attendance area must also complete a Discretionary Admission and Release (DAR) form. These forms must be signed by both the releasing and admitting Principal. Payment for the DAR process will not be collected until after the lottery (defined below). 3. All Dual Language applicants must attend Kindergarten Enrollment Day at his or her Home Assigned School. Parents may attend Kindergarten Orientation at either or both schools. See each school's website or the BCS website for Kindergarten Enrollment and Orientation Dates for each school. 4. Parents will be notified after May 15 and no later than Memorial Day about the outcome of the lottery (defined below).	
If my Home Assigned School does not have a BCS K-5 DL/I program, may I send my child to a school that does?	You may apply to any school with a BCS K-5 DL/I Program. Priority is given to siblings of current BCS K-5 DL/I participants. After siblings have been placed in the class, a lottery will be used so that two-thirds of the classroom may be made up of students who reside in the Home Assigned School's attendance area and one-third of the students reside outside the Home Assigned School's attendance area but still in the Home Assigned District. Students applying for a BCS K-5 DL/I program that is located outside his or her Home Assigned District will be considered for the program only after all students residing in that school's Home Assigned District have been placed in the program. **If a lottery is not needed (i.e. the number of applications is less than the number of classroom spaces available), enrollment will happen on a first-come first-serve basis.*	

Isn't Kindergarten too young? Transitioning my 5-year-old to school is hard enough. Why would I make it harder?	You are right; learning to go to school and understand school procedures and routines is a major transition, but it can happen in any language. Kindergarten is the recommended and opportune time to begin the BCS K-5 DL/I program. The use of props, puppets, and gestures at this early age encourages language learning. Your child will quickly learn to respond to his/her Kindergarten teacher's instructions and converse with his/her classmates in another language.
What if my Kindergarten child doesn't respond well or doesn't like it?	Like any Kindergartener, your child will be tired at the end of the school day, and it is even more exhausting when processing a new language. If you are worried your child is not enjoying school or thriving in the immersion environment, talk to the teacher and principal. Most students respond well to an immersion program as they are made to feel secure right from the start. Parents should allow at least nine (9) weeks of school, if not a full semester, to see how the child responds after getting through the transition of being in school.
Instructional Information	
Will my child be learning English?	Yes. Research shows that students in a DL/I program learn and often excel in their native language while also acquiring a second language. Learning a second language builds creative processing and problem-solving skills, which make your child more likely to absorb instruction in either language.
How can a Kindergarten student who only speaks English learn from a teacher who only speaks Spanish? Will my child be able to speak English in class until she learns enough vocabulary to communicate?	DL/I teachers speak and provide instruction primarily in Spanish and reserve English for emergencies or the adjustment period during the start of the school year. These teachers are experienced and understand how young children acquire language skills. They frequently use props, puppets, and gestures to help create connections and accelerate the learning process.
I don't speak another language so how will I be able to help my child at home?	The good news is you do not need to know a second language to support your child at home. The most important thing you can do at home is read to your child in your native language. Reading in any language supports the acquisition of reading skills such as fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension. Your child's homework should support what he has learned in class, so students should be able to tackle the assignment on their own. You will be able to identify what skill is being addressed and support learning in the skill, even if you can only help in your native language. Homework should not be a struggle. If it is, please talk with your child's teacher.

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What if my child is not progressing well in the BCS K-5 DL/I program?	If you have concerns about your child's progress in the BCS K-5 DL/I program, please contact your child's teacher to set up a conference. These concerns will be discussed and in-class assistance may be provided, as it would in any traditional program. If there is an extreme circumstance in which the child is demonstrating significant struggle, then the teacher, administrators, and parents will meet to determine the appropriate interventions, referrals, and program options.
Do dual language students qualify for and receive services from the Exceptional Children's Department (EC), Speech, English as a Second Language (ESL), and/or Academically/Intellectually Gifted (AIG) programs?	Yes, BCS offers these program services to eligible students. The process to qualify for these services is the same as it is for students in traditional classes. These services are provided in English.
Will my child take the End-of-Grade (EOG) tests in Spanish?	No, all students will take EOG tests in English.
How will my child learn the English skills he/she needs to be successful on EOGs and other assessments given in English?	In second grade, students begin to receive core content instruction in English. As students progress through the grade levels, the percentage of English instruction increases. Literacy skills learned in Spanish are transferable to English.
What are the expectations for language proficiency when exiting the BCS K-5 DL/I program?	Students entering the BCS K-5 DL/I program in Kindergarten and exiting the program at the end of 5th grade should demonstrate proficiency at the Intermediate Low-Mid level in Listening, Reading, Speaking, and Writing based on the AAPPL, a Spanish language proficiency assessment. The AAPPL assessment will be administered at Grades 2, 5 and 8.